



SAMOANS

THE PEOPLE OF WESTERN SAMOA

THE ISLANDS OF SAMOA ARE A GROUP OF ACTIVE volcanic islands that lie in the Pacific Ocean between New Zealand and Hawaii. The only large town on the four inhabited islands is Apia, the capital.

Fa'a Samoa

The Samoan way of life, known as *fa'a Samoa*, is a moral code on how to live life. It teaches about the church, community, family, and, most importantly, respect. The *aiga*, extended family, is all important and each *aiga* is led by a *matai*—a person selected for life who runs the social, economic, and political affairs of the family.



FOOD ON SAMOA

The families all own garden plots, where they grow fruit and vegetables such as bananas and taro. They also keep chickens and pigs and marinate raw fish by a method known as *oka*.



THE HOME

Samoan homes, called *fale*, have wooden frames, thatched sugar-cane canopies, and coconut-leaf blinds that roll down the sides to shade against the sun or protect against wind and rain. They are completely open and everyone sleeps together on woven mats. Twenty or more people may all sleep in a *fale* at one time.

DANCING

One of the things the Samoans are best known for is their dancing, one area of culture that has changed little from contact with Western civilization. The dances are performed by individuals or groups either sitting or standing.

